

ESSENTIAL SKILL

Sanitation

Keep Waste Away From People, Food, and Water

When toilets and running water stop working, sanitation can become a serious problem quickly. Food and shelter are not enough if human waste and dirty hands begin spreading disease.

CONTAIN IT. SEPARATE IT. KEEP CLEAN.

IF THE TOILETS STOP WORKING

First determine what failed

WATER SUPPLY OFF, SEWER WORKING**Manual flushing may be possible**

Use non-drinking water only after confirming the sewer or septic system is functioning and local officials have not told you to stop flushing.

**SEWER, SEPTIC, OR DRAIN SYSTEM
FAILED****Stop flushing**

Do not add more wastewater to a failed system. Set up an emergency toilet and follow local disposal instructions.

BACKFLOW WARNING

If sewage is backing up, keep people away from it and contact the utility, property manager, or septic professional.

BAG, ABSORB, SEAL, SEPARATE

Simple emergency toilet

Use a purpose-made emergency toilet system when available. For a short-term household backup, a sturdy lined toilet bowl or stable bucket can contain waste until authorities provide disposal instructions.

STEP 1

Line it

Place a strong plastic bag securely inside the empty toilet bowl or a stable bucket fitted with a toilet seat.

STEP 2

Absorb

After each use, cover waste with cat litter, sawdust, or wood shavings to absorb moisture and reduce odor.

STEP 3

Remove early

Do not let the bag become heavy or overfilled. Wear gloves and remove it carefully while it is still manageable.

STEP 4

Seal and label

Close the bag tightly, place it in a second bag if needed, and label it as human waste.

STEP 5

Separate

Keep sealed waste away from people, animals, food, and all water sources. Follow local public-health or waste-authority disposal directions.

Bag → Absorbent material → Seal → Separate

THE STRONGEST DAILY DEFENSE

Handwashing

Wash after using the toilet, handling waste, changing diapers, and before preparing food, eating, or caring for wounds.

Scrub for at least 20 seconds

USE SOAP AND SAFE WATER WHENEVER POSSIBLE

1

Wet

Wet hands with clean running or poured water.

2

Lather

Apply soap and rub palms, backs of hands, between fingers, and beneath nails.

3

Rinse and dry

Rinse with clean water and use a clean towel, paper towel, or air dry.

If soap and water are unavailable, use alcohol-based hand sanitizer containing at least 60% alcohol. Sanitizer is a fallback, not a replacement when hands are visibly dirty.

NO RUNNING PLUMBING REQUIRED

Simple handwashing station

SUPPLY

Water jug with spigot

Raise it above hand level so water can flow without touching the outlet.

WASH

Soap and drying method

Keep pump soap and clean paper towels or another clean drying method beside it.

CATCH

Basin or bucket

Collect wastewater so it does not create mud, slipping, or contamination.

Place one station near the emergency toilet and another near food preparation. Refill them with safe water and keep the spigot clean.

CREATE A HARD BOUNDARY

Protect the drinking water

✗ Empty waste near a well, spring, stream, pond, or stored water.

✗ Wash toilet equipment near drinking-water storage.

✗ Put dirty hands, cups, or utensils into clean-water containers.

✗ Use the same containers for waste and drinking water.

**Keep the toilet area downhill and away from any water source whenever site conditions allow.
Follow local rules for waste storage and disposal.**

CREATE TWO CLEARLY SEPARATED ZONES

Clean zone

Drinking water, clean containers, cooking utensils, food preparation, wound care

Waste zone

Emergency toilet, sealed human waste, garbage, wastewater, contaminated equipment

CONTROL WASTE IN ONE PLACE

Garbage and food preparation

Keep garbage bagged, covered, protected from animals and insects, and away from living areas, food, and drinking water. Establish one controlled garbage area instead of allowing trash to accumulate throughout the shelter.

A dirty kitchen can spread illness as easily as a dirty toilet. Keep hands, utensils, work surfaces, and food coverings clean. Anyone who handles human waste must wash thoroughly before touching food.

USE LIMITED WATER WHERE IT MATTERS

Personal cleanliness and special needs

When normal showers are unavailable, concentrate on hands, face, feet, underarms, groin, and wounds. Never bathe in water contaminated by sewage, floodwater, or toxic chemicals.

Plan for infants, older adults, and anyone with individual sanitation needs. Store diapers, protective underwear, wipes, gloves, skin-protection products, menstrual supplies, and needed disposal bags.

RECOMMENDED SUPPLIES

Simple sanitation kit

☐ Strong plastic bags

☐ Absorbent material

☐ Toilet paper

☐ Soap

☐ 60%+ alcohol hand sanitizer

☐ Disposable gloves

☐ Water jug with spigot

☐ Paper towels

☐ Garbage bags and ties

☐ Cleaning supplies

☐ Stable bucket or commode

☐ Personal sanitation supplies

☐ Labels and marker

☐ Printed local instructions

PREVENT DANGEROUS MIX-UPS

Keep everything labeled

Use large permanent lettering on the container and lid. Color alone is not enough, and no one should have to remember which bucket is which.

DRINKING WATER

WASHING WATER

HUMAN WASTE

GARBAGE

AVOID THESE

Common mistakes

✗ Keep flushing when the sewer or septic system is not working.

✗ Allow human waste to remain uncovered.

✗ Put waste near food or drinking water.

✗ Forget to wash after handling waste or removing gloves.

✗ Use drinking-water containers for waste.

✗ Allow garbage to build up in living areas.

✗ Handle waste and then prepare food without washing.

✗ Guess how bagged waste should be disposed of instead of checking local instructions.

✗ Wait until toilets fail to assemble supplies.

TRY THIS NOW

Three-day sanitation practice

Imagine the toilets and running water will not work for three days. Without using the emergency toilet, set up the complete system and answer:

1. Which bag and absorbent material will we use?
2. Where will the stable emergency toilet stand?
3. Where will sealed waste be isolated?
4. How will everyone wash and dry their hands?
5. Where will garbage and collected wastewater go?
6. How will drinking water remain protected?
7. Whom will we contact for disposal instructions?

Place the supplies together and make sure everyone can find them in the dark.

BEFORE AN EMERGENCY

Quick checklist

☐ I have strong bags, absorbent material, and toilet paper.

☐ I have soap, gloves, and effective hand sanitizer.

☐ I can set up a stable emergency toilet.

☐ I can create a handwashing station without plumbing.

☐ I know where sealed waste would be isolated.

☐ I can keep waste away from food and water.

☐ I have a controlled garbage plan.

☐ I have considered diapers and individual hygiene needs.

☐ I know where to get current local disposal instructions.

REMEMBER

A shelter without sanitation will not remain safe for long.

Human waste must be contained. Clean hands protect food and water.

BAG IT. ABSORB IT. SEAL IT. KEEP IT SEPARATE.

Official guidance

Check current local instructions during an emergency, especially for sewer use and human-waste disposal.

CDC: Personal Hygiene During an
Emergency

(<https://www.cdc.gov/water-emergency/safety/guidelines-for-personal-hygiene-during-an-emergency.html>)

CDC Archive: Sanitation Solutions During an
Emergency

(https://archive.cdc.gov/www_cdc_gov/healthywater/global/sanitation/sanitation-emergency-response.html)

FEMA: Basic Emergency Supply Kit

(<https://www.fema.gov/print/pdf/node/503732>)
